

HIGH SCHOOLS

Highland tops Norton, wins first Suburban title

By E.L. ROGERS
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

I love you, man.
"This is the greatest feeling ever, man," said Highland basketball player Brian Paul. "This is just great, man. Oh, man! Oh, man!"
Man, oh, man, this guy has a way with words.
This is the kind of gushing you get when your program wins its first conference title, and that's exactly what host Highland did last night when it bounced Suburban League rival Norton, 60-50.
"We knew Norton would be aggressive, because they had nothing to lose," said Highland's Brad

Reusch, who finished with a game-high 24 points. "I thought we were a little nervous at the beginning of the game. But after we got the nervous energy out of us, I thought we were ready to play."

And play Highland did. Before the game, the Hornets (15-5, 11-3 in the Suburban) had clinched at least a tie for first place. Highland, however, wanted the whole kit and kaboodle.

"Nah, we didn't want to tie for first," Paul said. "We wanted it all."

They got it. Of course, it wasn't easy. The first time these teams met, Norton (9-5, 13-7) played without 6-6 post player Brian Thompson because of illness. But

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BRAD REUSCH, Highland player

he played last night and paced Norton with 14 points.

"We knew we had to key in on him," said Highland's Jan Jagla, who scored 15 points. "They were a tough team to box out. They were physical."

The Panthers took an early

lead. They opened with a layup by John Schlitt (10 points), a free throw by Thompson and a 3-pointer from the left wing by Matt Vowles for a 6-0 cushion.

Highland eventually pulled within 10-9 on a 3-pointer from the left baseline by Jacob Brown

with 3:10 left in the period. But Norton finished the quarter with a 10-5 surge, taking a 20-14 lead into the second quarter.

"We played horrible defense in the first quarter," Paul said. "We always come out a bit sluggish."

Highland took its first lead, 21-20, with five minutes left in the half on a Reusch jumper. The Hornets stretched that lead to 25-20 before Norton got back on track. The Panthers pulled within 28-27 on two free throws by Thompson. However, Highland closed the half with a basket by Jagla.

"I thought our defense did a great job of making them miss shots," Norton coach Russ Swartz

said. "I thought we made Reusch work for everything he got. We hurt ourselves when we quit making shots. And we also hurt ourselves when we couldn't rebound the ball and get it out on our transition offense."

Highland made its biggest move in the third quarter. The Hornets grabbed their biggest lead, 39-29, midway through the quarter on a layup by Jagla. Highland entered the fourth period with a 43-35 lead.

Norton fought back. The Panthers closed to 55-50 on a Schlitt jumper with about a minute remaining in the game. But the Hornets sealed the game down the stretch with free throws.

Bees take charge

Medina wins 2nd straight Pioneer title

By TIM ROGERS
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Mike Chase said Medina just didn't want to lose. Like Christmas, the Bees wanted no ties.

So it went last night as Medina won its second straight Pioneer Conference championship when it took charge in the last nine minutes and went on to defeat stubborn Brunswick, 75-56.

"We didn't want to share the championship," said Chase, who if not the PC's MVP, then is its most underrated player. "Everyone on the team wanted to win. We didn't want to lose. We knew we weren't going to lose."

Had Medina lost, it would have shared the conference title with Midpark, which defeated North Ridgeville to finish second, one game behind the Bees (19-1, 13-1).

It was Medina's fourth Pioneer championship in the last six years, and the Bees became the first Medina team to win consecutive outright championships in almost 20 years.

Led by a sophomore whose game is as smooth as his face and a junior who has a knack of being in the right place at the right time, the Bees combined what coach Keith Sooy thinks are two of the most important ingredients to a championship.

"This team believes the team is first and all the individual stuff is second," said Sooy, who notched his 170th victory at Medina. "And, they honestly believe that defense wins championships."

That would be hard to argue, especially given what transpired during the game's final nine minutes.

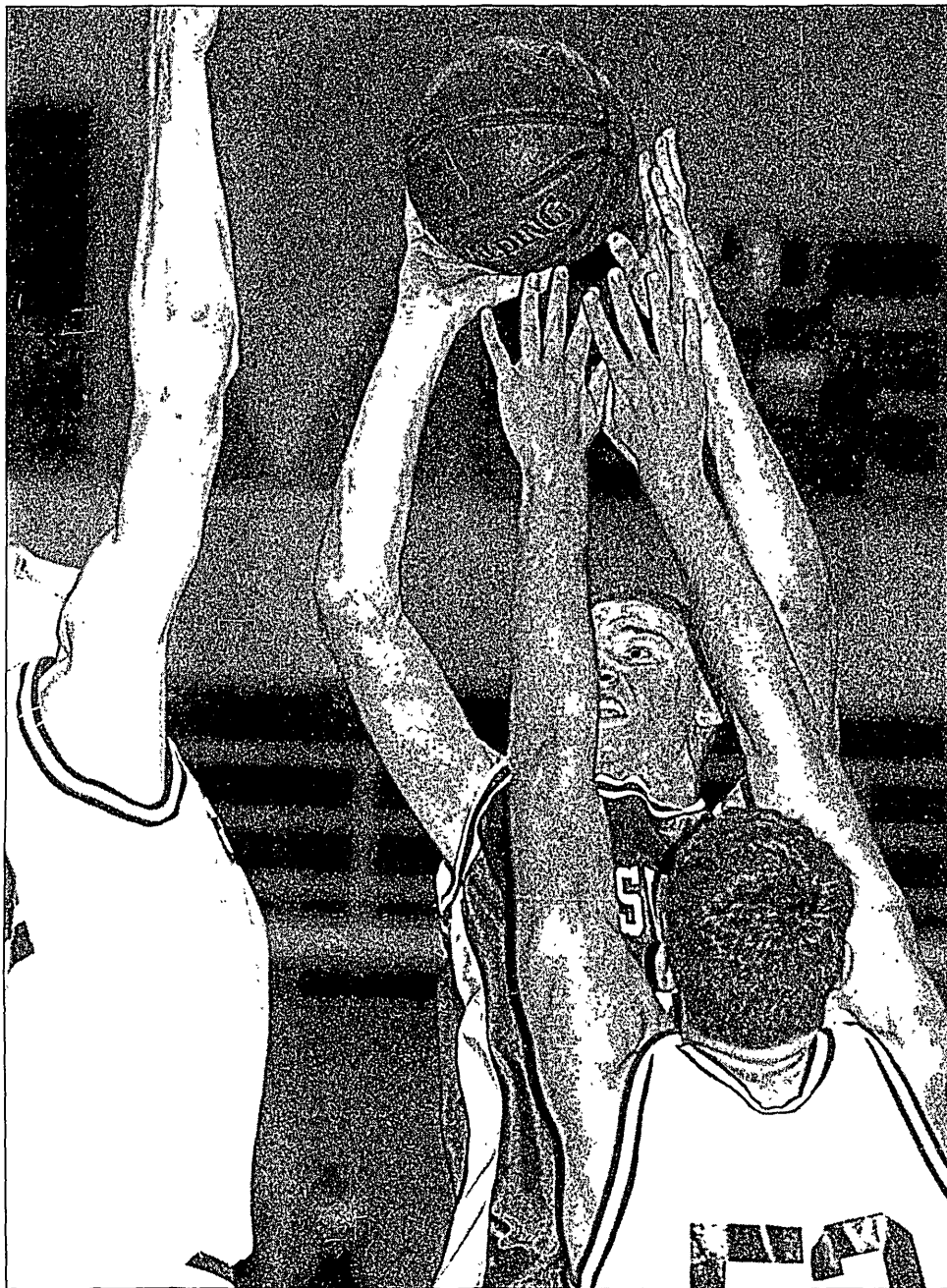
Medina, ranked fifth in The Plain Dealer Top 25 and 15th in the state, had a 54-50 lead with about one minute remaining in the third quarter. With five minutes remaining in the game, Medina led, 66-50. Brunswick (9-11, 5-9) did not score in the fourth quarter until sophomore Mike Mixon made a short jump shot with 2:41 to play.

"We've had stretches this season where we have gone big-time minutes and played excellent defense," said Sooy, whose team is seeded second behind powerful St. Edward in the Division I sectional-district at Midview High. "We can play good defense."

The Bees weren't bad offensively, either. They made 32 of 58 (55 percent) field-goal attempts and 7 of 12 free throws.

Sophomore guard Tony Stockman, who began the season on the junior varsity, scored 25 points to lead everyone. He made 10 of 20 field-goal attempts and scored 17 of his points in the second half. He also had five assists and led the team in a postgame dance around the conference championship trophy.

"He can flat-out shoot," Sooy



BILL KENNEDY / PLAIN DEALER PHOTOGRAPHER

Brunswick's Ryan Klebowski shoots over Mike Chase, left, and Travis Schwab during Medina's 75-56 victory last night.

said of Stockman, who was promoted to the varsity when senior Thomas Hodge was dismissed for disciplinary reasons. "Offensively, he can do a lot of things."

Sooy could say the same about the 6-5 Chase and throw in some defense for good measure.

"I don't know if he has a chance to win the MVP award, but I sure like him," Sooy said. "If you look at his total game — rebounding, playing defense, blocking shots and what he does for our team — I think he deserves it."

Chase finished with 14 points, 11 rebounds and two blocked shots. Sophomore Travis Schwab

came off the bench to score 16 points and get six rebounds.

Mixon, who got involved in a shooting match with Stockman in the early going, led Brunswick with 19 points and 6-5 senior Ryan Klebowski had 14 points and nine rebounds.

Medina took a 56-50 lead into the fourth quarter and Chase set the stage for the final eight minutes. He intercepted a pass and went the length of the court for a slam dunk. After a Brunswick timeout, junior guard Jeff Tomko duplicated Chase with another steal and a layup, and the Bees had a 60-50 lead with 7:27 re-

maining. Throw in a jump shot by Stockman with two seconds to play in the third quarter and the Bees were on their way to scoring 15 straight points.

"We figured if we kept on playing hard, Brunswick would eventually fold," Chase said.

As the Bees cut down the nets in celebration, several hundred fans remained behind. Like a good party, no one wanted to leave.

"I know I don't," Schwab said. "We have spent so much time in this gym leading up to this. This is the greatest."

Sort of like Christmas.

Rocky River nails 11 threes in win

By EDDIE DWYER
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

They wore their SWC champion T-shirts with pride, posed for several team pictures for friends and family members, and cut down the nets they had drained for nearly 32 minutes.

As Rocky River standout senior Sean Kennedy said: "You couldn't ask for a better way to go out."

And last night, the Pirates were never better.

Rocky River, behind an impressive display of long-range shooting and an aggressive man-to-man defense, wore down visiting North Olmsted, 80-47, and clinched a share of the Southwestern Conference boys basketball title.

The Pirates, ranked 13th in The Plain Dealer's Top 25 poll, closed their regular season at 18-2 and shared the SWC crown with Olmsted Falls by finishing 13-1 in conference play.

"I have always dreamed about a game like this, when they would come out and shoot like they're capable of," Rocky River coach Jim Rucki said after his team extended its winning streak to 14 games. "We have five or six guys who can step out and hit the 3-pointer."

The Pirates stepped out and stepped up as they erased a two-point deficit after the first eight minutes with the help of seven consecutive 3-pointers in the second quarter.

Junior forward Jeff Peate, who entered the game with a team-leading 16.1 points-per-game average, gave Rocky River a 21-18 lead by hitting his second 3-pointer with 7:01 remaining in the first half.

The Pirates pushed their lead to 27-22 on a 3-pointer by Kennedy with 5:41 left in the half, but North Olmsted responded with the third of six 3-pointers by senior guard Mike Husak. Husak finished with a game-high 22 points.

Rocky River, which won its first SWC title since the 1992-93

season, turned to the shooting of senior guard Connell Dolan, Peate and senior forward Bob Clutterbuck in building a 15-point halftime lead.

Two free throws by Peate and a 3-pointer by Clutterbuck increased the margin to 41-28, and the Pirates led, 43-28, at halftime after Peate hit a spinning one-hander along the baseline. Rocky River was 8-of-10 from 3-point range in the first 16 minutes and finished with 11 baskets from beyond the arc.

"We emphasize playing defense and rebounding," said Eagles coach Tim Schmotzer after his club slipped to 11-9, 8-6 in the SWC. "But Tuesday night, we gave up 87 points to Lutheran West, and tonight we gave up 80. Going into this week, we had only two games in which the opponent scored more than 60 points against us."

Peate, who led the Pirates with 20 points, including 17 in the first half, hit his fourth 3-pointer on the first possession of the second half.

North Olmsted closed to 50-40 on Husak's fifth 3-pointer with 3:57 left in the third quarter.

But Rocky River, which is seeded first at the Admiral King Division II sectional-district, picked up the pace at both ends of the court.

Sparked by strong moves inside by Clutterbuck, Dolan and junior post player Mike Woodward, the Pirates stretched their lead to 56-40 with 1:40 remaining in the third quarter.

A layup in transition by Dolan off an assist from Kennedy made it 58-40 and Rocky River took a 61-42 lead into the fourth quarter after Clutterbuck beat the buzzer with a 3-pointer from deep in the left corner.

"Yeah, everybody stepped up tonight," said Kennedy, who put the finishing touches on his last home game by slamming home a basket with 3:56 left. "Even the guys in the post were stepping out and hitting threes."

Olmsted Falls wins a share of crown

By DON FRIEDMAN
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

It wasn't pretty. In fact, it was downright sloppy. But then, that's the way Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue wanted it to be.

Olmsted Falls knocked off host Westlake, 78-59, to wrap up a share of the Southwestern Conference boys basketball championship last night. The Bulldogs won their third SWC title in a row, but this time they had to share it with Rocky River. Both teams finished with 13-1 records. The losses were to each other.

"We want to make it sloppy," Donahue said. "We're not a pretty team. We have no players who can shoot the eyes out of the basket."

"Our game is pressure. If we can get the game sloppy, that's to our benefit. Most teams don't practice as hard as we do or play a half-court game like we do. Defense does the job for us, and our defense is fine."

"Our next goal is the district." The Bulldogs will play in the Division II sectional at Rocky River.

"We have five sophomores on this team," Donahue said. "All the kids believe in each other. The newspapers, even people in the school and friends of our program did not expect us to win the SWC."

Then he came up with a startling fact. "We have three seniors on this team, Keith Knapp, Rob Szczec and Jeff Miller. When they were in the seventh, eighth and ninth grades, they won a total of two games."

The Bulldogs went 14-0 the last two years and 13-1 this season. "There is no one player we look to," Donahue said. "[Junior] Sean Radigan is our leader. He does what he has to do, whether he has to drive on the floor for a ball or whatever."

Last night's individual hero was

sophomore Manzie Williams. He led everybody with 18 points, but it was how and when he scored them that meant so much.

Falls struggled at the beginning. The Bulldogs led, 10-9, when Williams turned it on with 1:42 to play. He hit a 3-pointer. Twelve seconds later, he hit another 3-pointer and added a basket with 13 seconds left in the quarter.

All this while Falls was shutting out Westlake. As a result, the Bulldogs led, 18-9, after one quarter.

Williams didn't score in the second period. Falls was ahead, 37-30, early in the third quarter.

It was Williams to the front, again. He scored with 6:37 left, again with 5:41 and 5:15. His fourth basket of the third quarter came with 45 seconds to go and put Falls ahead, 57-35.

Williams' two eight-point quarters were the boosts Falls needed.

Three teammates were in double figures. Radigan had 14. Mike Gansey scored two baskets in each of the last three quarters for 12 points. Szczec had 10.

"It was not just me," Williams said. "The whole team got me the ball. Without those guys, I'm nobody."

"Every player tries to be a leader. There will be more new players next year, and hopefully, we'll win our fourth championship."

Westlake coach Art Daniels had nothing but praise for the Bulldogs.

"Yes, the game was sloppy," he said. "That's their style. They want the game to get sloppy, and they double-team you all over the floor."

"Their pressure keeps building. That gets you out of control, and they get easy baskets off their defense."

Westlake committed 23 personal fouls and Falls made 19 of 30 foul shots.

Bedford romps to co-championship

By BOB DOLGAN
PLAIN DEALER REPORTER

Swingman Dominic Crutchfield put on a show as Bedford cruised to the co-championship of the Greater Cleveland Conference with a 100-59 victory over host Willoughby South last night.

Crutchfield, a 6-3 junior, scored 29 points before Bedford coach Everett Heard mercifully pulled him for good with three minutes left in the third quarter.

Before that, Crutchfield was showing all the weapons in his arsenal: slam dunks, 3-point shots, tips, and drives. He had 23 points at halftime as the Bearcats led, 47-29.

"He's one of the best players I have seen in my 13 years in the GCC," said South coach Bob Bell.

Heard said: "He's just scratching the surface of what he can do if he gets serious about basketball."

Bedford improved to 14-6, 10-2 in the GCC, sharing the title with Euclid, which beat Mayfield last

night. The talented Bearcats would have been solo champions if they had not lost a game to Maple Heights last week.

"I would have liked to win it outright, but I'm just happy to get a piece of the pie," Heard said.

"We wanted to come out and play like champions," said Bedford guard Clarence "Trey" Lewis, who scored 10 points. Kamil Wilson (14), Antonn Melton (13) and Darrell Appling (12) were the other Bearcats in double figures.

Melton, a sophomore guard, scored all of his points in the final quarter. He hit three 3-pointers, the last with 28 seconds left to put Bedford at the century mark.

South (6-13, 3-9) got 14 points from 6-5 junior center David Walter and 13 from 6-3 guard Joe Severino.

"Their team was much too athletic for us tonight," Bell said. "They came out pumped up and took us out early."

Bedford went on top, 12-0, in

the first 2:10 as Crutchfield sank a 3-pointer and made a three-point play on a fast break. The 6-3 Appling put in a rebound shot, Wilson hit a jumper and Lewis sank two foul shots.

Severino and junior Matt Warner sank 3-pointers in the period, but Bedford led, 26-12, after one stop.

The Bearcats' press continued to force turnovers and produce fast breaks in the second period as Crutchfield hit another 3-pointer, a dunk and totaled 11 points. He sank 5 of 6 foul shots in the quarter and has made 86 of 91 for the season.

Severino had seven points in the quarter, including a 3-pointer. Bedford senior guard Brandon Reed made two 3-pointers and scored eight points in the third quarter, which ended with Bedford on top, 76-40, as Heard gave his reserves a chance to play.

Crutchfield scored six more points before his exit, but he also missed four makeable inside